

ZAYNYG WORLD

Ms. Mumble's Haunted Library

Book 1: The Book Ghosts

By Jose Quinones

FREE FIRST CHAPTER

Enjoy Chapter One on us — a gift from our family to yours.

Chapter One: The Boy Who Hid in the Library

Sam Rivera had a problem, and the problem's name was Dodgeball Danny.

Dodgeball Danny was the fastest thrower in the third grade at Willow Creek Elementary. He had once knocked a seagull's lunch right out of the sky. Nobody was safe. Not the big kids. Not the teachers. Not even Principal Pruitt, who now ate lunch indoors.

So every day at recess, while the other kids ran screaming onto the blacktop, Sam ran screaming into the library.

The library was the best hiding place in the whole school. It was cool and quiet and smelled like old paper and lemon polish. The tall wooden shelves stood in long rows like friendly giants, and between them were the coziest reading corners in the world. Nobody played dodgeball in the library. Dodgeball Danny was actually afraid of the library, because once a book about snakes fell on his head and he never recovered.

"Back again, Sam?" whispered Ms. Mumble.

Ms. Mumble was the librarian. She had a gray bun, a purple shawl with a hundred pockets, and a voice so soft you had to lean in to hear it. Every pocket of her shawl held bookmarks. She gave them away like other people gave away smiles.

"Books are sleeping," she whispered, pressing one finger to her lips. "We mustn't wake them rudely."

Sam nodded and tiptoed to his favorite corner, behind the 700s (which Ms. Mumble said was "the art section, where the books are extra dreamy"). He pulled out his favorite book — "Barnacle Bill's Big Voyage," about a pirate who sailed the seven seas looking for the world's greatest treasure — and read until recess was over.

Sam loved adventure books. He loved pirates and dragons and explorers and spies. He just didn't love real adventures, because real adventures were too... real. In books, nobody got hit in the face with a dodgeball.

That afternoon, Sam was so deep in Chapter Twelve that he didn't hear the bell ring. He didn't hear the other classes file out. He didn't hear Ms. Mumble lock the front doors, because she always checked the corners, and Sam's corner was very well hidden behind a beanbag shaped like a turtle.

When Sam finally looked up, the library was dark.

"Ms. Mumble?" Sam whispered.

No answer. The tall windows showed a purple-orange sunset. The library was empty. Sam was locked in.

Sam's heart went THUMP-thump-THUMP. He stood up, his knees wobbly, and tiptoed toward the front desk. That was when he heard it.

Tick. Tock. Tick. Tock. BONG.

The big grandfather clock in the corner — the one Ms. Mumble said was older than the school itself — began to chime. Sam counted on his fingers. One... two... three... The clock kept going. Ten... eleven... twelve...

THIRTEEN.

The clock chimed thirteen times. That was impossible. Clocks did not chime thirteen times. Sam knew this because he was in third grade and third graders know about clocks.

Then the whispering started.

It came from the walls. From the shelves. From inside the books themselves. Hundreds of tiny voices, all whispering at once, like leaves in a windstorm.

"Shhh," whispered the voices. "Shhh. The books are waking up."

A blue glow rose from the pirate section. A silver glow floated out of the ballet books. A warm yellow glow bubbled up from the cookbooks. The glows swirled together in the middle of the room, spinning faster and faster, until — POP! POP! POP! — three ghosts appeared.

Sam opened his mouth to scream. Nothing came out. His scream was stuck somewhere between his stomach and his throat, probably hiding behind his ribs.

The first ghost was big and burly, with a bushy beard and a captain's hat covered in barnacles. He was see-through and slightly damp, and he smelled like the ocean.

"AVAST!" he boomed, which was strange, because he was also whispering. It was a booming whisper. "Who dares wake the Book Ghosts?"

The second ghost was graceful and glowing silver. She had wings like a moth and wore a tutu made of moonlight. She spun in a slow circle and bowed to Sam.

The third ghost was round and jolly and green. He wore a tall chef's hat and an apron that said KISS THE COOK in drippy letters. He waved a wooden spoon at Sam.

"Hello, hello!" he said cheerfully. "Are you the new page? You look like a page. A very nice page. Would you like some soup?"

Sam's scream finally found its way out. Unfortunately, it came out as a squeak.

"EEEEEP!"

The pirate ghost clapped his hands over his ears. "Great gusts of wind! It's a landlubber! A real, live landlubber!"

"He's adorable," said the moth ballerina, floating closer. "Look at his hair. It's like a little thundercloud."

"Does the thundercloud want soup?" asked the pickle ghost hopefully.

Sam pressed himself against the bookshelf. "P-p-please don't eat me," he stammered.

The three ghosts looked at each other. Then they burst out laughing — a sound like wind chimes in a breeze.

"Eat you?" boomed the pirate. "Lad, we don't eat boys! We eat WORDS. Well — one of us eats words. The rest of us are very polite."

"I'm Captain Barnacle," said the pirate, sweeping off his barnacled hat. A tiny crab waved from inside it. "Late of the good book 'Barnacle Bill's Big Voyage.'"

"I am Luna Lightfoot," said the ballerina, twirling. "Late of 'The Moth Ballerina.'"

"And I," said the pickle, bowing so low his chef's hat nearly touched the floor, "am Professor Pickles, late of 'The Pickle Professor's Cookbook.' And you are...?"

"S-Sam," said Sam. "Sam Rivera. I'm in third grade. I'm locked in. The clock chimed thirteen. Am I dreaming?"

"You're not dreaming," said a soft voice behind him.

Sam spun around. Ms. Mumble stood in the doorway of her office, holding a lantern. She didn't look surprised at all.

"Ms. Mumble!" Sam cried. "You can see them too?"

"Of course, dear," Ms. Mumble whispered. "Somebody has to shelve them in the morning. Now — introductions are done. Sam, meet the Book Ghosts. Book Ghosts, meet Sam. He's going to help us."

"We are?" said Sam and the ghosts together.

Ms. Mumble smiled her crinkly smile. "The library is in trouble, Sam. And these three need something only a real, live reader can give them. But that story starts tomorrow. Tonight — " she glanced at the clock, which was now chiming a perfectly normal twelve — "tonight, young man, your mother is probably worried sick. Let's get you home."

As Ms. Mumble unlocked the front doors, Captain Barnacle leaned down to Sam and whispered his booming whisper, "Come back tomorrow, lad. We Book Ghosts have been waiting a hundred years for a reader like you."

"Why me?" Sam asked.

Luna twirled once more, her wings scattering silver dust. "Because," she said softly, "you're the first one who ever hid in the library on purpose."

Want to know what happens next?

Sam just met the Book Ghosts — a pirate, a ballerina, and a chef who lives for soup. But someone is trying to tear the library down, and only Sam and the ghosts can save it.

Get the full book — all 7 chapters of spooky-fun adventure:

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